PANDEMIC OF COMPLACENCY

DON'T LET THE MILDER OMICRON WAVE, BETTER PREPAREDNESS AND PANDEMIC FATIGUE FOOL YOU. COVID IS NOT DONE WITH US YET

By SONALI ACHARJEE



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

HAVING ASKED OURSELVES OVER AND OVER whether the pandemic might finally be over, many of us have been only too willing to lower our guard—and our masks. After a swift ascent to its peak across January-February, cases in India declined faster than in most other countries—our average daily cases dropped by 98.9 per cent in seven weeks, while they declined by only half in other nations in the same period. The apparent mildness of the new variants also bred a false optimism. Both Omicron and its subvariants wrought much less havoc on the body than the earlier editions of the corona virus—the most common symptoms not going beyond persistent high fever, cough and bodyache. Many thought this portended a declining phase for the pandemic, when the reproduction, or 'r', value—the average number of people an infected person passes on the virus to—drops below 1.

The Covid-19 virus, as it has repeatedly demonstrated, is wilier than that. Its graph in India is rising again, after almost two months of declining cases. In the week ending May 1, the country registered 22,000 new cases, almost 41 per cent higher than the week before. India's r-value, per an estimate by The Institute of Mathematical Sciences in Chennai, was 1.07 in the week ending April 18. Twenty states

1.07

INDIA'S R-VALUE IN THE WEEK ENDING APR. 18, AS ESTIMATED BY THE INSTITUTE OF MATHEMATICAL SCIENCES, CHENNAI. FOR THE PANDEMIC TO BE CONSIDERED IN DECLINING PHASE, R-VALUE HAS TO BE <1